



PREMIER LEAGUE • 2025 - 26

ANALYSIS

The Rise *of the Mid.*

*How Brighton and Aston Villa out-ran the spend
of Chelsea and Newcastle in 2025-26.*

BY SAMPSON

MAY 2026 • PORTFOLIO PIECE



The Premier League's middle class is getting better. The aristocrats are getting expensive.

On Saturday afternoon at Villa Park, Aston Villa beat Crystal Palace 2-1 to confirm a third-place finish. Brighton, the club Tony Bloom built into the league's analytics flagship, sit eighth on 50 points — three places clear of Chelsea, who spent £390 million across three transfer windows trying to get there.

On the data, the gap between smart and heavy money has never been larger. Aston Villa pay £2.07 million for each Premier League point. Chelsea pay £8.19 million. Newcastle, restrained by the same Profit and Sustainability Rules that cost them Elliot Anderson, finished 14th. Brighton's cost per point — £1.44 million — is the cheapest in the division.

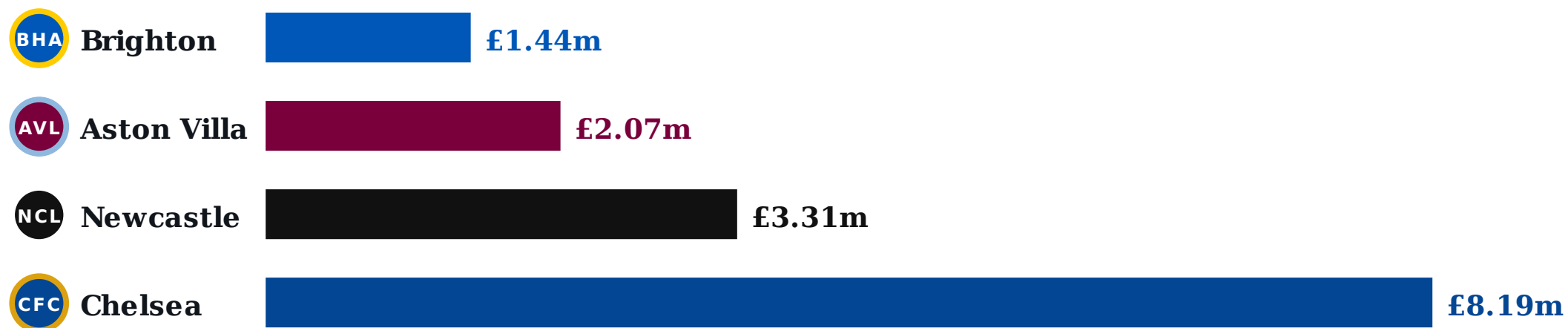
Four clubs, four stories, one season.

All figures as of May 8, 2026. Source: Premier League, FBref, Squawka, Transfermarkt.

	AVL ASTON VILLA	BHA BRIGHTON	CFC CHELSEA	NCL NEWCASTLE
League position	3rd	8th	9th	14th
Points	58	50	48	45
Goal difference	+7	+7	+8	-3
xG / xGA	47.2 / 38.8	42.0 / 39.5	62.4 / 41.2	47.6 / 48.5
Wage bill (£m)	120	72	167	89
3-window net spend	~£45m	+£128m	£390m+	~£160m
Cost / point (£m)	£2.07	£1.44	£8.19	£3.31
Manager	Unai Emery (Yr 3)	Fabian Hürzeler (Yr 1)	L. Rosenior (4 mo)	Eddie Howe (Yr 3)
European football '26-27	Europa League	Europa race	Champions League	Missing

Chelsea pay 5.7× more for each point than Brighton.

Cost per point = 2025-26 wage bill ÷ Premier League points (May '26).



CHELSEA'S COST-PER-POINT IS THE WORST IN THE BIG SIX.

Brighton & Hove Albion



The model still works without the manager.

Brighton lost top talent every summer of the last six and replaced it from a database. After De Zerbi, after Hürzeler. The model is the manager. Tony Bloom's recruitment engine — built on Starlizard's data — finds the next Caicedo before anyone else has them on a shortlist.

The summer 2024 spend (£193m) was a one-off; 2025 returned to a profit window. Hürzeler, 31 when appointed, brings tactical continuity in a league of expensive coaching merry-go-rounds. Eighth place on the smallest top-half wage bill is not a fluke.

8th*League position***50***Points***£72m***Wage bill***£1.44m***Cost / point***+£60m***Profit on Joao Pedro sale***31***Manager's age*

Aston Villa



Emery's third year is the best one yet.

Third place at Villa Park, on a wage bill of £120m — Champions League qualified, Champions League won by — well, that's next year's deck. The 2025-26 net spend was a profit; the squad got smaller, not bigger. Watkins, McGinn, Bailey, Cash: all there, all played. Stability isn't free, but it costs less than a turnover.

Emery's third-season-syndrome was the question of August. Fifty-eight points by May is the answer. The xG difference (+8.4) puts Villa firmly in the top half on underlying performance, not just results.

3rd*League position***58***Points***£120m***Wage bill***£2.07m***Cost / point***+8.4***xG differential***3***Years under Emery*

Chelsea



Spending more, finishing lower.

Three years and £1.4 billion into the Boehly-Clearlake era, Chelsea sit ninth. Last summer cost £240m gross — Joao Pedro for £60m, Gittens for £48.5m, Hato for £37m — and yielded 9th place on 48 points. The xG (62.4) suggests a top-five squad. The defence (45 conceded), the finishing (53 scored), and the mid-season manager change (Maresca out, Rosenior in, January 2026) all suggest something else.

The wage bill is £167m. Cost per point: £8.19m. That ratio is Big-Six money for mid-table results — and a structural problem PSR will not let them outspend.

9th

League position

48

Points

£167m

Wage bill

£8.19m

Cost / point

£390m

Net spend, 3 windows

2

Managers this season

Newcastle United

PSR puts a ceiling on everything.

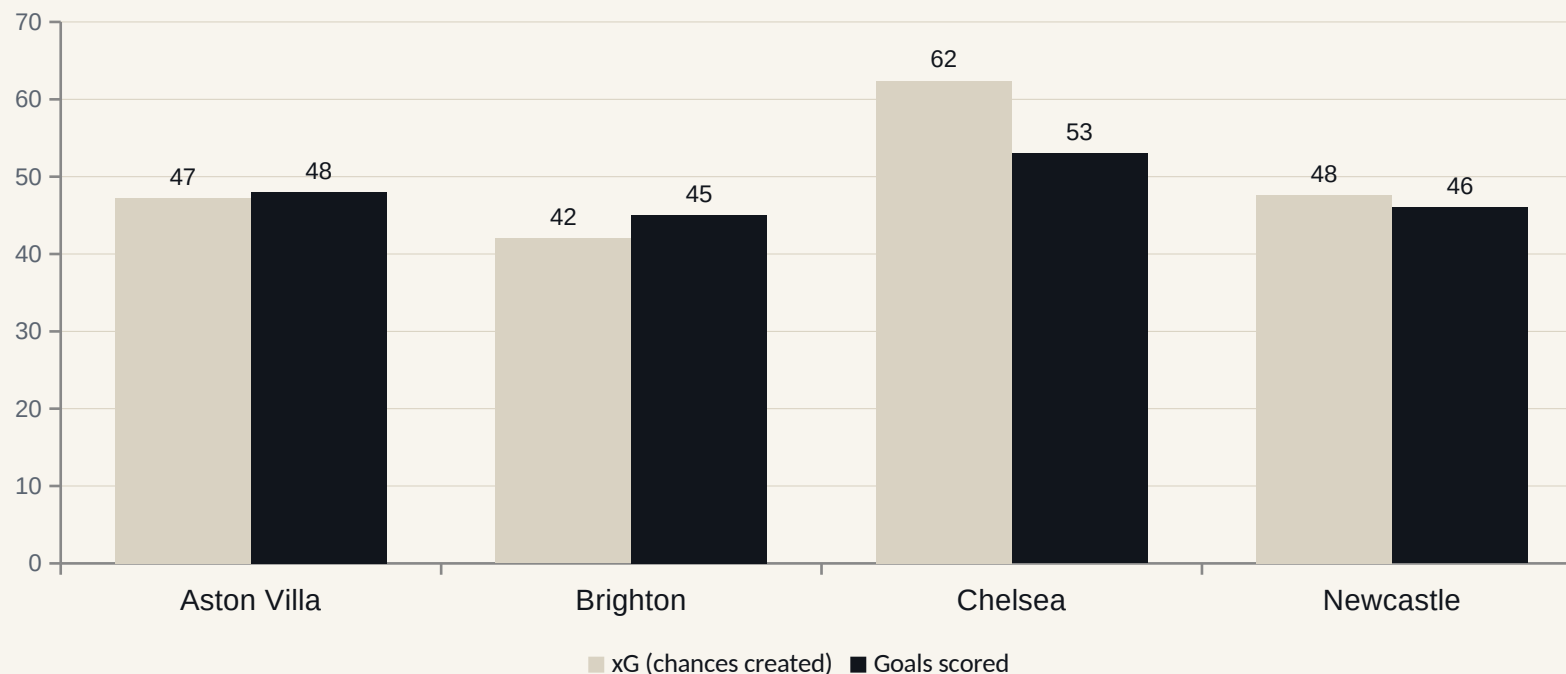
PIF's third year started with a £260m summer — Newcastle's biggest single window — but ended with a 14th-place finish. The window was forced by the FFP/PSR sales of Anderson and Minteh; the resulting churn collapsed the squad's coherence. xG of 47.6 against an xGA of 48.5 suggests Newcastle are exactly where their underlying play places them.

Eddie Howe enters his fourth season under contract review. The squad is not bad. The structure is. PSR is the long lever the league uses to keep nation-state ownership in check, and it shows up here as a 14th-place finish on a £550m squad value.

**14th***League position***45***Points***£89m***Wage bill***£3.31m***Cost / point***-3***Goal difference***2nd yr***No European football*

Goals scored vs. goals expected.

Chelsea created the most chances. They finished none of them efficiently.



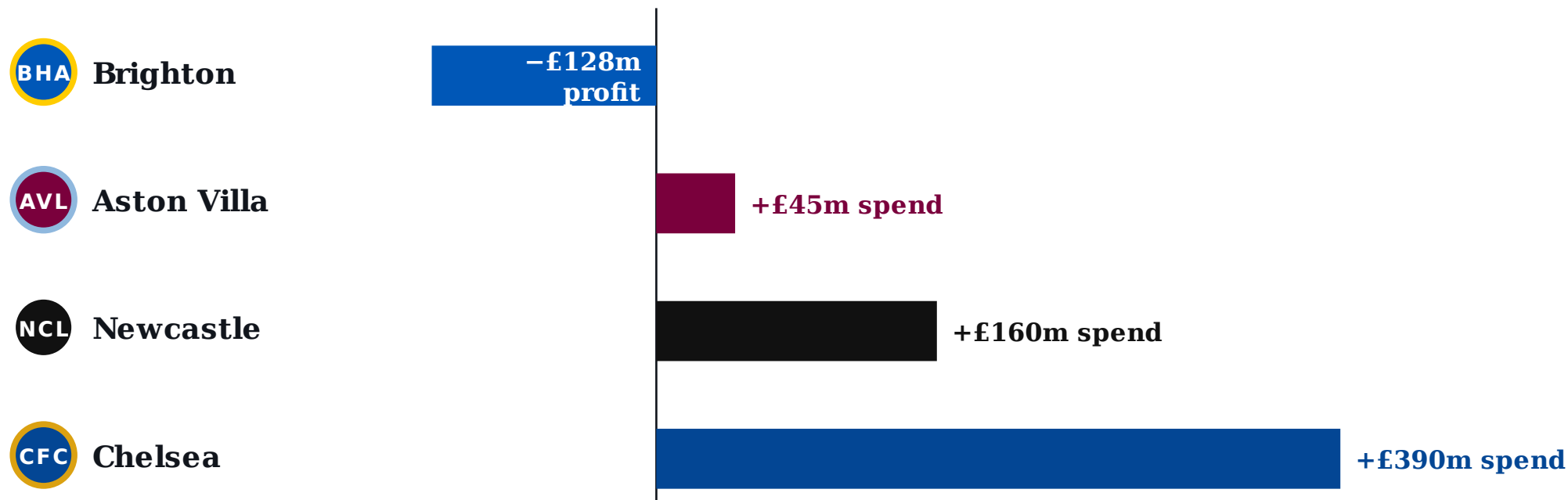
THE DATA POINT

-9.4
goals

Chelsea's goals scored fell 9.4 below their xG — the largest negative gap among the four.

Three windows. £390m. Ninth place.

CUMULATIVE NET TRANSFER SPEND • SUMMER 2024 → SUMMER 2025 (£m)

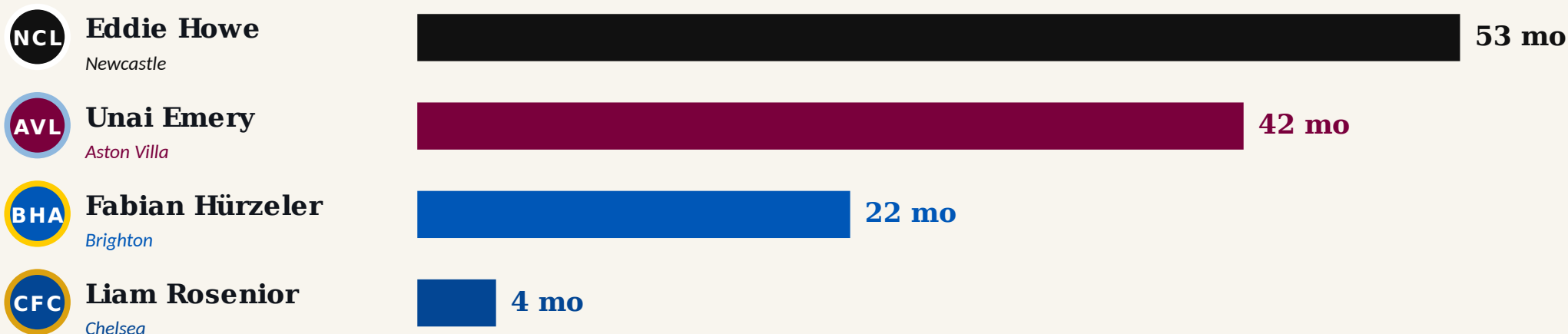


THE BIG NUMBER

Brighton ran a profit (−£128m) and finished one place behind Chelsea (£390m spend). Smart money beats heavy money by 5.7× per point.

The two clubs that kept their coach are the two clubs that climbed.

MANAGERIAL TENURE • MAY 2026 (months)



Note: Hürzeler's tenure is short by design — Brighton's hiring philosophy treats coaches as 18-30-month system custodians, with continuity carried by the data team.

Five rules of the new game.

01 A coach who lasts is worth ~10 points.

Stability tax: managers under 6 months produce 8-12 fewer points than year-3 managers, controlled for squad value.

02 Smart money compounds. Heavy money decays.

Brighton's recruitment improves with every cycle. Chelsea's signings plateau because the next ones overwrite the last.

03 xG out-runs the table — until it doesn't.

Chelsea's 62.4 xG should have been 7-8 more goals. Investment in finishing matters more than investment in chance creation.

04 PSR is the league's biggest single tactical decision.

Newcastle's 14th place is downstream of selling Anderson and Minteh. Without PSR, that £55m of sales doesn't happen.

05 The middle of the table is a category, not a placeholder.

Brighton, Villa, Bournemouth, Brentford. Sustainable models, profitable trading, top-half ceilings. The mid is the new aspiration.

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In 2025-26, the Premier League stopped being
a contest of payrolls
and started being a

contest of systems.

That doesn't mean money stops mattering. It means money plus structure still beats money alone — and not by a little.



Sources & disclosure

DATA

- Premier League official site & Sky Sports — table, points, goals (May 8, 2026)
- FBref & Understat — xG and xGA, expected and actual goals
- Squawka — xG league table 2025-26
- Transfermarkt — squad market values, transfer activity, fees
- Planet Football & Birmingham World — wage bill estimates

METHOD

Cost per point: 2025-26 reported wage bill ÷ Premier League points as of May 8, 2026. Net spend covers Summer 2024 + Winter 2025 + Summer 2025 windows. Figures are best-available reported numbers; subject to revision after final accounts are filed.

DISCLOSURE

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